



Questions and answers on the pre-enlargement policy reviews

Strasbourg, 6 October 2026

What's included in the pre-enlargement policy reviews?

EU enlargement is a strategic investment in Europe's peace, security and prosperity. It delivers significant political and economic benefits for both the Union and enlargement partners. To fully unlock these benefits the EU must be ready to welcome new members.

Today's Communication, *Preparing for a wider Union*, outlines the policy orientations and practical steps needed to prepare the EU for future enlargements.

The pre-enlargement policy reviews identify clear priority actions across four key areas: governance, values, policies and budget. The reviews show that the Union can accommodate a larger membership through targeted adaptations within the existing Treaty framework and accession treaties.

The package reaffirms that enlargement remains a merit-based process, determined by reform progress of each acceding country.

Today's package will feed into the strategic discussion among Member States on enlargement and reforms, including at the European Council in October.

Why is EU enlargement a priority now?

Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine, alongside growing instability in Europe's neighbourhood and wider global competition, has underlined the importance of a stronger and more united Europe. In this context, enlargement is not only a political objective but also a geopolitical investment in peace, security and long-term stability across the continent. By extending democracy, rule of law and prosperity across our continent, enlargement can strengthen the Single Market, create new opportunities for trade and investment, and increase the EU's economic resilience and political weight.

For European citizens and businesses, the benefits are concrete. Enlargement can support economic growth, create jobs, improve infrastructure, strengthen connectivity, and make supply chains more secure. It can also help the EU and its partners respond more effectively to shared challenges such as energy security, migration, climate change and external threats.

Ultimately, enlargement is about building a safer, stronger and more prosperous Europe, united by shared values and common interests.

How will the EU adapt its governance for new members?

In the current geopolitical environment, the EU must adapt its governance to make decision-making swifter and more effective. The Union should make full use of the possibilities offered by the existing Treaties to strengthen its capacity to act and prepare for future enlargement.

The Commission is recommending using existing Treaty mechanisms, such as [passerelle clauses](#) and [enhanced cooperation](#). The Commission is proposing to use passerelle clauses to move to qualified-majority voting in selected areas such as sanctions, tackling tax fraud and fiscal measures in energy policy. This could be accompanied by appropriate safety measures for essential national interests, making decision-making more effective while respecting Member States' essential national interests. The Commission also recommends using qualified majority voting for the opening of the negotiating clusters and intermediate decision in accession negotiations.

When the objectives of a Union policy cannot be attained within a reasonable period by the Union as a whole, the Treaties provide another means of advancing these objectives: enhanced cooperation. Enhanced cooperation enables a group of at least nine Member States to establish closer cooperation

in a specific policy area, subject to the conditions laid down in the Treaties. The Commission will review pending proposals to identify where enhanced cooperation could help overcome a persistent blockage.

The Commission is committed to working with the European Parliament and the Council on the institutional and operational adjustments required for future accessions.

How is the EU planning to ensure new members uphold EU values and rules?

Rule of law monitoring starts before accession and continues after a country joins the Union. The Commission will progressively extend the Rule of Law Report to further candidate countries as they become ready, while new Member States will also be covered by the full EU rule of law toolbox after accession.

As announced in the [2025 Communication on EU enlargement policy](#), future accession treaties should include stronger safeguards against serious backsliding on commitments undertaken during the accession negotiations. Today, the Commission is proposing a common framework for these safeguards. Future accession treaties would provide for targeted remedies where serious shortcomings risk undermining the proper functioning of the Union.

This will build on the tools already available under the Treaties and existing mechanisms applying to current Member States.

What are the new safeguards?

The Commission is proposing a set of safeguards providing temporary and targeted remedies for risks identified during accession preparations. In particular, the Commission proposes to strengthen the three sectoral safeguards used in previous enlargements – covering the economy, the internal market and justice and home affairs – by significantly extending the period during which they can be activated.

A new institutional safeguard would address serious breaches of [Article 2 TEU](#) values and the principle of sincere cooperation. Available measures could extend to suspension of voting rights in the most serious cases. A further option concerns decision-making rights during the first years of membership, where for a limited period, a new Member State would also commit not to oppose EU decisions on future enlargements or bilateral disputes.

These safeguards would complement pre-accession monitoring from the closure of negotiations until accession, allowing corrective action if needed. All safeguards would be temporary, targeted, reversible and subject to regular review.

How will the EU finance future enlargement while preserving existing priorities?

The proposed 2028–2034 MFF already provides the main budgetary framework for future enlargement, including a revision mechanism when a new Member State joins. The Global Europe instrument proposed under the MFF would provide tailored pre-accession support, combining grants, loans, and guarantees, to accelerate reforms. Progressive integration of the candidate countries into EU programmes will smooth the transition, while MFF revision mechanisms will adjust allocations if and as necessary at the time of accession.

Objective-based financing is central to this approach. Pre-accession instruments, such as the [Growth Plans for the Western Balkans](#) and [Moldova](#) and the [Ukraine Facility](#), already link disbursements to concrete reforms, ensuring candidates are ready to manage EU funds upon accession. For the next Multiannual Financial Framework, the objective-based plans will remain the main implementation vehicle for enlargement partners, linking payments to the delivery of reforms and investments, and, once they become Member States, also facilitating alignment with the relevant provisions of the National and Regional Partnership Plans.

The [Montenegro financial package](#) presented in June 2026 demonstrates how country-specific plans will bridge pre- and post-accession funding, avoiding implementation gaps. As negotiations approach completion, the Commission will set out the funding transition in a specific financial package for each enlargement country.

Support under the objective-based plans must remain conditional on reform progress and improvement of national financial control processes, with suspension or reductions where conditions

are not met.

How will candidate countries benefit from gradual integration before accession?

Closer integration should bring tangible benefits to citizens and businesses in both the EU and candidate countries, well before full membership. It can help candidate countries progressively participate in selected parts of the EU internal market and benefit from closer cooperation in strategic areas, while supporting reforms and strengthening their preparedness for accession. Access will depend on progress in accession preparations, readiness in the policy concerned and strategic alignment with the Union.

The Commission will map existing instruments and identify opportunities to deepen integration in strategic sectors such as energy, transport, digital and defence, helping strengthen connectivity, investment and resilience. Gradual integration will complement and reinforce the accession process by providing concrete incentives for reform, building administrative capacity and strengthening mutual trust. Participation will remain conditional on progress in the relevant areas and fully aligned with the principles and requirements of the accession process. Measures should also remain reversible where necessary, ensuring that closer integration goes hand in hand with sustained progress on reforms.

To support this approach, the Commission will launch annual dialogues with enlargement partners to take stock of progress, identify further opportunities for gradual integration and address remaining gaps or barriers. This will provide a regular framework for assessing implementation, strengthening cooperation and ensuring that gradual integration delivers practical results on the ground.

What are the next steps?

The Commission invites the European Parliament and the Council to advance discussions and institutional preparations and policy measures.

As part of the 2026 Enlargement package the Commission will present indicative roadmaps for Montenegro, Albania, Moldova and Ukraine, provided they maintain reform momentum.

For more information

[Press release](#)

[Communication 'Preparing for a wider Union'](#)

[Staff Working Document on pre-enlargement policy reviews](#)

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Press contacts:

[Paula PINHO](#) (+32 2 292 08 15)

[Guillaume MERCIER](#) (+32 2 298 05 64)

[Yuliya MATSYK](#) (+32 2 291 31 73)

General public inquiries: [Europe Direct](#) by phone [00 800 67 89 10 11](#) or by [email](#)